Introduction to International Politics 2601

Case Study: U.S.-Afghanistan War and Withdrawal from Afghanistan

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U.S. - Afghanistan War (Key Dates) -

- 1990s - Soviet withdrawal from Afghanistan following end of Cold War
- 2001 - Al-Qaeda attacks on U.S., 2001 U.S. military engagement begins, Taliban regime ends
- 2003 - NATO assumes control of ISAF forces in Afghanistan (est. 2001 - 2014, aid)
- 2014 - Initial U.S. troop withdrawal proposed
- 2017 - U.S. commitment continued
- 2020-2021 - U.S. troop withdrawal
- 2021 - Taliban resumes power in Afghanistan

U.S.-Afghanistan War: A **Structural Realist** Explanation

(Structural) Realism focuses on -

- Security and related strategic interests
- The power structure of the international system

Features of events to consider -

- How Soviet withdrawal *reshapes the structure* of the region
- How the U.S. responds to a "power-neutral" state(Afghanistan)
- Remnant Cold War dynamics

Recall: **Unipolarity** -

- one state having a preponderance of power in the international system.
- Example: Following the end of the Cold War, the United States had lost its "balancer" in the East (USSR)

Unipolar systems -

- a hegemon is often in a position of influence
- but may be continually engaged in conflict as *challengers arise* (why challengers?)

Unipolar systems -

- a hegemon is often in a position of influence
- but may be continually engaged in conflict as *challengers arise* (which challengers?) **unipolar systems may invite multiple challengers against one state**

Result?

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Hegemons may be more likely to escalate

Result -

- **Hegemons may be more likely to escalate**
- U.S. security interests through this lens focus on continued security threats

What are U.S. security interests through this lens?

- Repressing a *potential* aggressor emerging from power vacuum
- post-Cold War dynamics
- threats emerging by additional actors (next section)

The Credibility Trap

The **Credibility Trap** -

- states escalate or prolong conflict to maintain credibility
- may lead to unwanted engagement

Example:

- A senior Administration official said after the withdrawal announcement, "We have communicated to the Taliban in no uncertain terms that if they do conduct attacks against U.S. or allied forces . . . we will hit back hard" (U.S. Mil. Withdrawal and Taliban Takeover in Afghanistan: Frequently Asked Questions, 8

U.S.-Afghanistan War: A **Constructivist** Explanation

Recall: **Constructivism** -

- ideas **give meaning** to material factors (or, material factors alone do not suffice to explain events)
- ideas/identity are shaped over time
- states may maintain multiple identities and interests

Can we *refine* our understanding of this case study using this lens?

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Well, of course.

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Well, of course. **Let's try.**

How histories of Soviet engagement in Afghanistan shapes non-state actor (esp. Taliban, Al-Qaeda) dynamics?

- anti-West sentiments (ideology),
- a neutral pocket to be shaped through newly emerging political ideologies

This requires us to "look inside the black box" to understand the nature of the threat in the region.

How histories of Soviet engagement in Afghanistan shapes non-state actor (esp. Taliban, Al-Qaeda) dynamics?

- anti-West sentiments (ideology),
- a neutral pocket to be shaped through newly emerging political ideologies **note some similar features of events understood through a different lens**

Introducing Non-State Actors

Non-State actors -

- actors who operate outside of a state government
- may include violent actors (e.g., terrorists, guerilla fighters), economic actors, or social actors

- How might we incorporate non-state actors into our existing analytical frameworks?
- What role might non-state actors play in this case?

Realism

Realism

- power politics
- self-help
- unipolarity and emerging threats (what, if any, additional features are considered in our analysis with non-state actors?)

Example: The Rationalist Explanation for War (Fearon 1995)

- war is irrational given the costs of war
- yet states escalate in conflict

War occurs *rationally* as a result of:

- Information Asymmetry/Incentives to Misrepresent
- Credibility to Maintain Commitments
- Issue indivisibility

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- Information Asymmetry/Incentives to Misrepresent
- Credibility to Maintain Commitments
- Issue indivisibility **more frequently disregarded in traditional war, but may be a stronger feature of non-state actor engagement - we will return to this later in the semester**

War occurs *rationally* as a result of:

- Information Asymmetry/Incentives to Misrepresent **resource allocation, mobilization**
- Credibility to Maintain Commitments **alliance behavior**
- Issue indivisibility **ideological motivations**

Constructivism

Constructivism -

- ideas give meaning to material factors
- actors relate differently

Constructivism -

- *Anti-West/Anti-U.S. (specific) sentiment* and *fundamentalist ideological motivations*
- Responses to democratization and by democratic-driven foreign policies

What role did the 9/11 attacks play in either framework?

What role did the 9/11 attacks play in either framework?

- emerging threat (realism)
- ideological threat (constructivism)

Understanding the U.S. Withdrawal from Afghanistan

A **Structural Realist** lens -

- will focus on **security concerns** relating to withdrawal
- continued engagement (e.g., Obama Admin. increase in troop presence) results from concerns of insecurity *from* the state
- decisions to withdraw focus primarily on the weight of those concerns

A **Constructivist** lens -

will consider security concerns from *within* the state (i.e., conflict dynamics among non-state actors)

continued engagement results from domestic-level factors and an emphasis on anti-West/anti-U.S. ideologies or alliances built along these dimensions

Other levels of analysis?

Levels of analysis -

- System
- State
- Individual

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- System
- **State**
- Individual

State level -

- emphasizes state/societal dynamics or within-state dynamics
- Unit(s) of Study: American public opinion - changes from entrance (RATF) to withdrawal, competing interests - level of decision-making (e.g., Amb. Khalilzad)

Levels of analysis -

- System
- State
- **Individual**

Individual level -

- consider psychological, situational, or personal factors
- Unit(s) of study: U.S. Presidents, Trump Admin., Biden Admin. - individual beliefs and interests

Next lecture: Case Study: NATO Enlargement and the Russian War in Ukraine